

Session 7: Ezekiel the Watchman

Key Takeaways

- God appoints Ezekiel as a watchman but prevents him from being a mediator as he faces the impending destruction of Jerusalem.
- God's justice demands judgment for Israel's violence and unfaithfulness, but in his covenant he promises that blessing will come through Israel. God must lead his chosen people through death to bring them to resurrection hope on the other side.

Translation and Literary Design of Ezekiel 3:16-27

¹⁶ And it came about at the end of the seven days,
that **the spoken-word of Yahweh** came to me **saying** ,

¹⁷ "Son of Man, **I have made you a watchman** **for the house of Israel** ,
and when you hear a **word** from my mouth,
then you shall give them a **warning** from me."

a ¹⁸ When I **say** to **the wicked man** , 'You are going to **die** !'

b and you do not **warn** him

and you do not **speak** to **warn** the wicked from his wicked way in order to preserve his **life** ,

c then the wicked man will **die** in his guilt,
but his blood I shall require from you.

b' ¹⁹ But as for you, when you **warn** **the wicked man** ,

and he does not turn from his wickedness or from his wicked way,

c' he will **die** in his guilt

and you will deliver your own life .

a ²⁰ And when **the righteous man** turns from his righteousness and does evil,

b then I will place a stumbling block before him;

he will **die** , because you did not **warn** him,

c in his sin he will **die** ,

and his righteous deeds which he did, they will not be remembered,
and I shall require his blood from you.

b' ²¹ But as for you, when you **warn** him, **the righteous man** ,

that the righteous man should not sin,
and he does not sin,
c' he shall surely **live**, for he was **warned**;
and you will deliver your own life.

22 And **the hand of Yahweh was upon me** there
and he **said** to me,

"Get up, go out to the plain,
and there I will **speak** with you."

23 **And I got up and I went out to the plain,**
and behold there was **the glory of Yahweh**,
it was **standing** like **the glory** that I saw by the river Chebar,
and I fell on my face.

24a And **the spirit entered me**
and she **stood** me on my feet

24b and he **spoke** to me
and he **said** to me,

"Go, close yourself up inside your house.

25 And as for you, son of man,
look, **they will put cords on you**,
and they will bind you with them,
and you will not go out in their midst.

26 And I will make **your tongue cleave to your mouth**
and **you will be silent** and **you will not be a mediator for them**,
for they are a rebellious house.

27 And when I do **speak** to you,
I will open your mouth
and you will **say** to them,
'Thus says [the Lord] Yahweh.'
The one who hears, let him hear;
and the one who desists, let him desist,
for they are a rebellious house.

Ezekiel 3:16-27. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021)

Ezekiel's Prophetic Sign Acts

Like ancient street theater, the sign acts are a multimedia expression of the prophetic message (see 1 Kgs. 11:29-31; 2 Kgs. 13:14-19; Hos. 1-3; Isa. 20; Jer. 32; art of Banksy). The symbolic actions not only visually

reinforce the message, but also prefigure or guarantee the event being alluded to.

3:17-21: Ezekiel as Israel's Watchman (Connection to Ezek. 18, 33:7-9)

Ezekiel is like an army sentinel posted on the city walls looking for the approach of the enemy. The metaphor is profound and ironic.

Israel is in danger from an enemy—Yahweh himself (“a warning from/about me” [3:17](#), Babylon is just an agent, see also [Jer. 27](#)). Israel has been given a watchman, commissioned and posted by Yahweh himself (what enemy posts a sentinel in his target city?). Yahweh is both enemy and guardian of Israel. He wants to save Israel, but will not let their apostasy go unchecked.

3:16, 22-27: Ezekiel Bound in His House and Mute

The first paragraph ([Ezek. 3:16-27](#)) portrays Ezekiel's prophetic role among the people, and it's a bit of paradox. He is, first of all, a “watchman” (צִפְּהָ), a sentinel guard on the city wall who is to warn the people of any approaching danger. This metaphor leads to the vocabulary of “warning” (הַזְהִיר) in the following paragraph ([Ezek. 3:18-24](#)). This is a fairly straightforward description of the prophetic task, and the same image is used of other prophets as well ([Isa. 21:6](#), [52:8](#); [Mic. 7:7](#); [Hab. 2:2](#)).

In the literary design of the paragraph, Ezekiel's role as a watchman is set on analogy to the final unit in [Ezekiel 3:24b-27](#), where Ezekiel is bound up and unable to speak among the people.

16 And it came about at the end of the seven days,
that **the spoken-word of Yahweh** came to me **saying** ,
17 “Son of Man, **I have made you a watchman for the house of Israel** ,
and when you hear a **word** from my mouth,
then you shall give them a **warning** from me.”

3:24b And he **spoke** to me
and he **said** to me,

“Go, close yourself up inside your house.

25 And as for you, son of man,
look, **they will put cords on you** ,
and they will bind you with them,
and you will not go out in their midst.

26 And I will make **your tongue cleave to your mouth**
and **you will be silent** and **you will not be a mediator for them** ,
for they are a rebellious house.

27 And when I do **speak** to you,
I will open your mouth
and you will **say** to them,

‘Thus says [the Lord] Yahweh.’
The one who hears, let him hear;
and the one who desists, let him desist,
for the are a rebellious house.”

Ezekiel 3:16-27. Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Ezekiel (2021)

Ezekiel is bound with cords (3:25). This could refer (1) to the exiles’ resistance to his message (cf. the persecution of Jeremiah, Jer. 20:1-2, 37-38). But this seems odd, because the elders of the Israelite exiles are regularly depicted as coming to visit Ezekiel (see 14:1, 20:1). This could (2) be connected to Yahweh’s statement that he will “bind” (Ezek. 4:8) Ezekiel in the sign act about the siege of Jerusalem, where he will be tied up in house to carry the sins of Israel. This scene begins to look curiously like a combination of images from the *Aqedah* of Isaac (Gen. 22) and the Day of Atonement (Lev. 16).

This divinely imposed house arrest is explained in the following lines, as Ezekiel is to become “mute” (Ezek. 3:26, נִאֵלֵם). This mute state will last for the next seven years (until Ezek. 33:21-24). Ezekiel will be unable to speak except for the prophetic oracles Yahweh gives him to speak.

Yahweh’s goal in making his prophet mute is to prevent him from playing the role of a “mediator” or “advocate” (3:26, אִישׁ מוֹכִיחַ). The “mediator” is a person who stands in between two parties in conflict and advocates for the interests of one or both.

Jacob and Laban

Genesis 31:36-37 NASB*

³⁶ Then Jacob became angry and contended with Laban; and Jacob said to Laban, “What is my transgression? What is my sin that you have hotly pursued me? ³⁷ Though you have felt through all my goods, what have you found of all your household goods? Set it here before my brothers and your brothers, that they may **mediate** between us two.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

David and the Men of Benjamin

1 Chronicles 12:16-17 NASB*

¹⁶ Then some of the sons of Benjamin and Judah came to the stronghold to David. ¹⁷ David went out to meet them, and said to them, “If you come peacefully to me to help me, my heart shall be united with you; but if to betray me to my adversaries, since there is no wrong in my hands, may the God of our fathers look on it and **advocate for me**.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Job and Elohim

Job 9:32-33 NASB*

³² For [*Elohim*] is not a man as I am that I may answer him, that we may go to court together. ³³ There is no **mediator** between us, who may lay his hand upon us both.

In situations of conflict, the mediator acts as a neutral party who represents the interests of both groups and tries to negotiate a settlement. This is precisely the “Moses-model” of the prophet who inserts himself between Yahweh and the people and advocates that Yahweh forgive the sins of the people.

- Noah on Mount Ararat making his sacrifice after the flood: [Genesis 8:20-23](#)
- Moses on Mount Sinai in the golden calf narrative: [Exodus 32-33](#)
- Aaron in the wilderness in the story of Korah’s rebellion: [Numbers 16-18](#)
- Samuel in the story of Israel’s idolatry with the ark: [1 Samuel 6-7](#)
- Isaiah in the Assyrian crisis of Hezekiah’s day: [2 Kings 18-20](#)
- Huldah in the story of Josiah’s covenant renewal: [2 Kings 22-23](#)
- Amos’ three acts of intercession: [Amos 7-8](#)

Amos 7:1-3 NASB

¹ Thus Yahweh *Elohim* showed me, and look, he was forming a locust-swarm when the spring crop began to sprout. And look, the spring crop was after the king’s mowing. ² And when it had finished eating the vegetation of the land, I said,
“Lord Yahweh, please forgive!
How can Jacob endure,
for he is small?”
³ Yahweh changed his mind about this.
“It shall not be,” said Yahweh.

These stories present a moment of crisis and conflict between God and his people, and the mediator steps in and offers a sacrifice of surrender, advocating for the guilty party. And in all of these stories, Yahweh forgives.

Yahweh Prevents the Mediator

Yahweh prevents two prophets from playing the role of mediator, and they both happen to live in the same period during the years leading up to the destruction of Jerusalem. While in exile, Ezekiel is told not to intercede for guilty Israel, and at the same time in Jerusalem, Jeremiah is given the same order from Yahweh.

Jeremiah 7:16 NASB*

¹⁶ As for you, **do not pray for this people,**
and **do not lift up cry** (רנה) **or prayer** (תפלה) **for them,**
and **do not intercede** (פגע) **with me;**
for I do not hear you.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jeremiah 11:14 NASB

Therefore **do not pray for this people,**
nor lift up a cry or prayer for them;
for I will not listen when they call to me because of their disaster.

Jeremiah 14:11-12 NASB

¹¹ So the LORD said to me,

“Do not pray for the welfare of this people.

¹² When they fast, I am not going to listen to their cry;

and when they offer burnt offering and grain offering, I am not going to accept them.

Rather I am going to make an end of them by the sword, famine and pestilence.”

Uniquely, Jeremiah and Ezekiel are told not to intercede for Judah and Jerusalem because the ruin of Israel and the destruction of the city and temple are inevitable. But because Yahweh has a pattern of listening to the petition of his prophets, he orders them to simply stop interceding.

This portrait significantly nuances Ezekiel’s role. He is to warn Israel of the coming disaster, but he is not to intercede on behalf of Israel or portray any sense of hope on this side of the Babylonian onslaught. He is simply to announce its inevitable arrival, and only then will his mouth “open” to say something new. In the final line of [Ezekiel 3:27](#) is a small seed of hope that will blossom into the restoration poems of Ezekiel 34-48. But for now, it’s only bad news.

This entire scene sets the stage for Ezekiel’s sign acts in [Ezekiel 4:1-5:17](#): a mute, bound man shut up in his house, burning with emotion, acting out these strange symbolic stories to his fellow refugees.

Reflection Question

How do you understand Ezekiel’s role? What has God sent him to do or not do?